

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM
AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH

Philosophy Optional - Paper II · Complete core-first master rail · Topic 09

01

FOUR AXES BEFORE ANY THEORY

Name the axis; a win on one does not settle another.

TRUTH / ALETHIC

Which doctrines are true, false, symbolic or partly adequate?
One Real with non-exhaustive formulations is one pluralist answer.

SALVATION

Can another path genuinely liberate or save? Several efficacious paths may even terminate in different ends.

EPISTEMIC ACCESS

What should disagreement do to confidence? Conciliation, steadfastness, humility or suspension are distinct options.

COEXISTENCE

Freedom, reciprocity and non-coercion regulate civic life without requiring truth-agreement.

NAME THE AXIS BEFORE THE THINKER.

02

EXCLUSIVISM → INCLUSIVISM → PLURALISM

The discriminating question is: who sets the terms of judgement?

EXCLUSIVISM

One revelation has uniquely decisive truth and/or saving authority. Strength-determinate content. Burden, privileged warrant and contingency of birth. It need not be coercive.

INCLUSIVISM

Others contain partial truth or receive salvation through the home tradition. Rahner's "anonymous Christians": grace, not secret membership. Cost: asymmetry.

PLURALISM

Several authentic responses or different real ends; denies exhaustive possession, not truth. Not relativism, indifference, syncretism or sameness.

THE TRIAD IS A MAP, NOT A VERDICT.

03

ATTRIBUTION AND CHRONOLOGY CONTROL

Use dated anchors only where they prevent anachronism.

1. 258

Cyprian, Epistle 73: salus extra ecclesiam non est. The compressed extra ecclesiam nulla salus is later.

1215 - 1302 - 1442

Lateran IV, Unam Sanctam, Florence: conciliar hardening of the later formula.

1965

Lumen Gentium 16 and Nostra Aetate move Roman Catholic teaching decisively toward inclusivism.

1689 - 1859 - 1945

Locke on incoercibility; Mill on harm and epistemic gain; Popper's bounded paradox of tolerance.

1985 - 1995

Fogelin on deep disagreement; Heim's Salvations on genuinely different religious ends.

CITE THE WHOLE CHAIN, INCLUDING THE 1965 QUALIFICATION.

04

HICK I — THE COPERNICAN REVOLUTION

A possibility hypothesis built from four premises, not a proof.

1 - DIVERSITY

One revelation has uniquely decisive difference is strongly correlated with birth-context.

2 - TRANSFORMATION

Multiple traditions produce saints and moral-spiritual transformation.

3 - EQUAL CONCERN

A universally concerned God resists arbitrary birthplace-based salvation; this premise is theological.

4 - HYPOTHESIS

Traditions may reject being redescribed as culturally limited appearances; the One Real may be authentically experienced through different conceptual schemes.

THREE DOMAINS SUPPORT A POSSIBILITY CLAIM; NONE ALONE PROVES IT.

05

HICK II — REAL AN SICH / MANIFESTATIONS

The Kantian analogy explains plurality but generates the noumenal objection.

KANTIAN MODEL

Real an sich: transcategorical. Religious schemes mediate personal and non-personal manifestations (personae / impersonae). Hick departs from Kant by making the Real causally related to experience.

NOUMENAL PRESSURE

If the Real is beyond categories, existence, causality and goodness seem illicitly predicated. Formal predication protects consistency but can make the Real explanatorily thin.

THE REAL EXPLAINS DIVERSITY ONLY BY PAYING THE PRICE OF THINNESS.

06

HICK III — TRANSFORMATION AND ITS COSTS

Self-centredness – Reality-centredness assesses authenticity, not joint truth.

CRITERION

Moral-spiritual fruits offer a cross-traditional test where doctrinal comparison lacks a neutral court.

LIMITS

Coarse-grained; cannot discriminate equally transformative traditions; does not make contradictions true.

IDENTITY / MISSION

Traditions may reject being redescribed as culturally limited appearances; the objection must be heard, not declared solved.

TRANSFORMATION TESTS AUTHENTICITY, NOT PROPOSITIONAL IDENTITY.

07

PLANTINGA AND D'COSTA — THE PARITY EXCHANGE

Serious answers defend exclusivism before criticising it.

PLANTINGA

Arbitrariness: pluralism is contested too. Arrogance: dissent accompanies ordinary philosophy. Irrationality: disagreement may reduce warrant, not erase it. Result: permissibility, not truth; birthplace remains.

D'COSTA

Pluralism is covert exclusivism: its second-order account is treated as uniquely true and revises first-order traditions. Hick's "hypothesis, not creed" reply does not remove all adjudicating authority.

NO VIEW FROM NOWHERE: ASK WHICH FRAMEWORK IS CORRIGIBLE.

08

FOUR PLURALISMS — ONE LABEL, INCOMPATIBLE ANSWERS

Ask first: one ultimate, several ends, dialogical method, or plural ultimates?

HICK / IDENTIST

One Real; many conditioned responses; transformation criterion.

HEIM / DIFFERENTIAL

Communion, non-dual realisation and cessation are different destinations; preserves self-description, loses one ultimate.

PANIKKAR / COBB

Mutual transformation: dialogue changes both parties; primarily a method.

GRIFFIN / DEEP

Process-based pluralism permits plural ultimates: creativity, God, cosmos.

"PLURALISM" NAMES INCOMPATIBLE THEORIES—DISCRIMINATE THEM.

09

RGVEDA 1.164.46 — FOUR DISCIPLINES

A high-value citation becomes a factual error if its native context is erased.

CITE

Īkām sad viprā bahudhā vadanti; aśa vāṃsya iṇdriē hymn; attributed to Dṛighatamas.

CONTEXT

Its own subject is naming Vedic deities: Indra, Mitra, Varuna, Agni, Garutman, Yama, Matarisvan.

BRIDGE

The inter-religious extension is a nineteenth- and twentieth-century Vivekananda-Radhakrishnan-Gandhi development and must be argued.

PAYOFF

The verse supplies a structure—one referent, many namings—not proof that every religion reaches one end.

ONE REFERENT / MANY NAMES IS A STRUCTURE, NOT A COMPLETE ARGUMENT.

10

VIVEKANANDA — UNIVERSAL RELIGION

Plurality of path follows from plurality of temperament.

MECHANISM

Different capacities require knowledge (jñāna), devotion (bhakti), action (karma) and meditative discipline (rāja). Non-dual ground plus realisation—not doctrinal uniformity—is the test.

EVALUATION

Chicago 1893: acceptance, not condescending toleration. Harmony need not homogenise; yet Vedānta may function as a hidden superior framework. The pluralist/inclusivist status is contested.

UNITY WITHOUT HOMOGENISATION—WITH THE ASSIMILATION COST STATED.

11

RADHAKRISHNAN · GANDHI · JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

Three Indian resources do different philosophical jobs.

RADHAKRISHNAN

Diverse interpretations of common spiritual experience (anubhava). Risk: perennialist reduction.

GANDHI

Equal respect plus fallibilism. Sarva-dharma-samabhāva is a modern summary formula, not an unverified verbatim slogan.

JAIN LOGIC

Many-sidedness (anekantavāda) → standpoint (nāyavāda) → conditional predication (syādvāda) → sevenfold scheme (saptabhāṅgī). Regulated realism; not "anything goes".

MANY-SIDEDNESS REGULATES PREDICATION; IT DOES NOT ABOLISH TRUTH.

12

ABSOLUTE TRUTH WITHOUT EPISTEMIC ABSOLUTISM

Expose the suppressed premise in the 2022 question.

REFERENT

What reality is about may be absolute.

FORMULATION

Every statement is finite, linguistic and scheme-bound.

ACCESS

Knowledge may be partial, perspectival and corrigible.

SALVATION

Whether truth liberates exclusively is a further question.

SUPPRESSED PREMISE

"A finite formulation can exhaust the absolute." Advaita, Jain conditional predication and Hick each deny it differently.

ONTOLOGICAL ABSOLUTISM DOES NOT ENTAIL EPISTEMIC MONOPOLY.

13

HARD CONTRADICTION — THE LIMIT PLURALISM MUST ADMIT

Route difference; never manufacture harmony.

LEVEL

Ultimate / conventional; without qualities / with qualities.

SYMBOL

Literal contradiction may be re-read as non-literal disclosure only with argument.

STANDPOINT

A claim may hold in one stated respect and not another.

DIFFERENT END

Communion, non-dual realisation and cessation may be irreducible ends.

RESIDUE

Creator / no creator and permanent self / no-self cannot both be true in the same respect. Acknowledge what remains.

HARD CONTRADICTION MUST BE ROUTED, THEN RESIDUE ACKNOWLEDGED.

14

PEER AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

Unresolvability is epistemic, not alethic.

PEER DISAGREEMENT

Conciliationism / equal weight: Feldman, Christensen. Steadfastness: Kelly, van Inwagen. The independence principle is the hinge.

DEEP DISAGREEMENT

Fogelin (1985): no shared framework propositions; Wittgensteinian hinges. Religion differs over sources, criteria and frameworks. Persistence proves neither relativism nor pluralism; it requires procedural virtues.

DEEP DISAGREEMENT EXPLAINS PERSISTENCE WITHOUT VINDICATING A PARTY.

15

TOLERATION — COMPONENTS, PARADOX, LADDER

Tolerance is indispensable but insufficient.

PERMISSION

Powerful majority permits a minority on sufferance.

COEXISTENCE

Mutual modus vivendi to avoid conflict.

RESPECT

Reciprocal recognition as equal moral-political persons.

ESTEEM

Positive valuation of what is worthwhile in the other.

FOUNDATIONS

Objection + acceptance reasons + power. Locke 1689; Mill 1859; Rawls; Popper 1945 only against those rejecting argument for violence. Aśoka Rock Edict XII commends concord (saṃvadya).

TOLERATION BY THE STRONG IS PERMISSION UNTIL IT BECOMES RESPECT.

16

RELIGIOUS FREEDOM — RIGHTS BUNDLE AND HARD CASES

Possible and necessary, but never unlimited or perfectly neutral.

BUNDLE / JUSTIFICATION

Conscience; profess; practise; propagate; change or leave; freedom from compelled observance; association. Grounds: incoercibility, autonomy, fallibility and social peace.

HARD PROBLEMS

Belief/practice asymmetry; coercion or fraud versus persuasion; Shachar's multicultural vulnerability; wall of separation versus Bhargava's principled distance; state adjudication through essential religious practices.

PROTECT CONSCIENCE; JUSTIFY LIMITS ON PRACTICE BY HARM AND RECIPROCITY.

17

CONFLICT — CAUSE, MARKER, MOBILISER, LEGITIMISER

Do not answer the history question with a list of wars.

CAUSE

Religion independently generates conflict: must be proved case by case.

MARKER

Religious label marks a conflict rooted in land, power or economy.

MOBILISER

Sacred identity organises pre-existing grievance.

LEGITIMISER

Religious language sanctifies decisions taken on other grounds.

CONTROL

Kimball = typology, not law. Cavanaugh 2009; Armstrong 2014; Sen 2006. Counter-evidence: Aśoka, Bhakti-Sūfi universalism, abolition, civil rights, satyāgraha and interfaith work.

RELIGION IS OFTEN A MARKER OR MOBILISER, NOT AN ISOLABLE CAUSE.

18

RELIGION AS A GLOBAL UNIFIER — CONDITIONAL VERDICT

Religion is a high-amplitude force, not an intrinsically unifying one.

UNIVERSALIST ETHICS

Moral scope must extend beyond the in-group.

FALLIBILIST EPISTEMOLOGY

Commitment must permit dialogue, correction and charity.

NON-MONOPOLISED IDENTITY

Political actors must not reduce persons to one affiliation.

EVIDENCE / COUNTER

Durkheim: 1893/1993 Parliaments; Hans King's Global Ethic. Against: in-group demarcation, Huntington as criticised thesis, Roy on territoriolised reactive forms.

UNIFICATION DEPENDS ON ETHICS, EPISTEMOLOGY AND THE POLITICS OF IDENTITY.

19

PYQ ROUTES AND EXAMINER-READY ANSWER PINE

Twelve verified parts, 2018–2025; answer the directive, not an adjacent topic.

PYQ LOAD

2018: E-I-P [20]. "Truth is one" [15]. 2019: unifier [10], central dispute [20]. 2020: conflict history [10], tolerance [10]. 2021: Absolute Truth [10], freedom [10]. 2022: inevitable exclusivism [20]. 2023: conflict + truth [15]. 2024: notion [10]. 2025: Vedāntic pluralism / Vivekananda [20].

PARAGRAPH ENGINE

CLAIM → named evidence/example — what it proves — qualification. Example: ontological unity does not entail epistemic monopoly. Advaita's nirguna/saguna distinction and Jain syādvāda deny exhaustive access, but same-respect contradictions remain.

TRAPS

Pluralism ≠ relativism · inclusivism ≠ pluralism · tolerance ≠ truth · RV verse needs context · Cyprian wording must be exact · Vatican II cannot be omitted · Plantinga must be stated before criticism · Hick ≠ Heim · Huntington is a thesis, not a finding.

QUALIFIED VERDICT

The strongest position combines truth-commitment, epistemic fallibilism, equal freedom and dialogue. Hick secures parity at the cost of an elusive Real; Vedāntic unity risks hidden hierarchy; Jain many-sidedness disciplines claims without abolishing truth.

TRUTH-COMMITMENT + FALLIBILITY + FREEDOM + DIALOGUE, WITH CONTRADICTION INTACT.